

A GRAMMAR OF AGENCY

Moral Action in an Age of Artificial Intelligence

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Section I: The Problem of Agency in an AI Age

We live in a world increasingly shaped, fitted, and mediated by artificial intelligence. Our phones no longer simply let us talk to mom; they tell us the time, they track our steps, monitor our sleep, measure our heartbeats, and anticipate our needs. Most of us cannot recall a best friend's phone number, read a map, or navigate by compass — because the machine does it for us, faster and more reliably than we can. Bit by bit, we have outsourced formerly human skills to systems designed to optimize utility and maximize efficiency.

The question is no longer whether we will outsource. It is what remains when we have outsourced everything we can.

At some point, the outsourcing must stop. And it must stop with us — with an interior stance, a posture of agency: I will not offload my moral responsibility to the machine. AI cannot parse a moral plane. Its outputs have form without substance, fluency without accountability. An AI response is not an act. It does not relate to the real world; it receives inputs and produces outputs. It does not stand before the good. It does not choose.

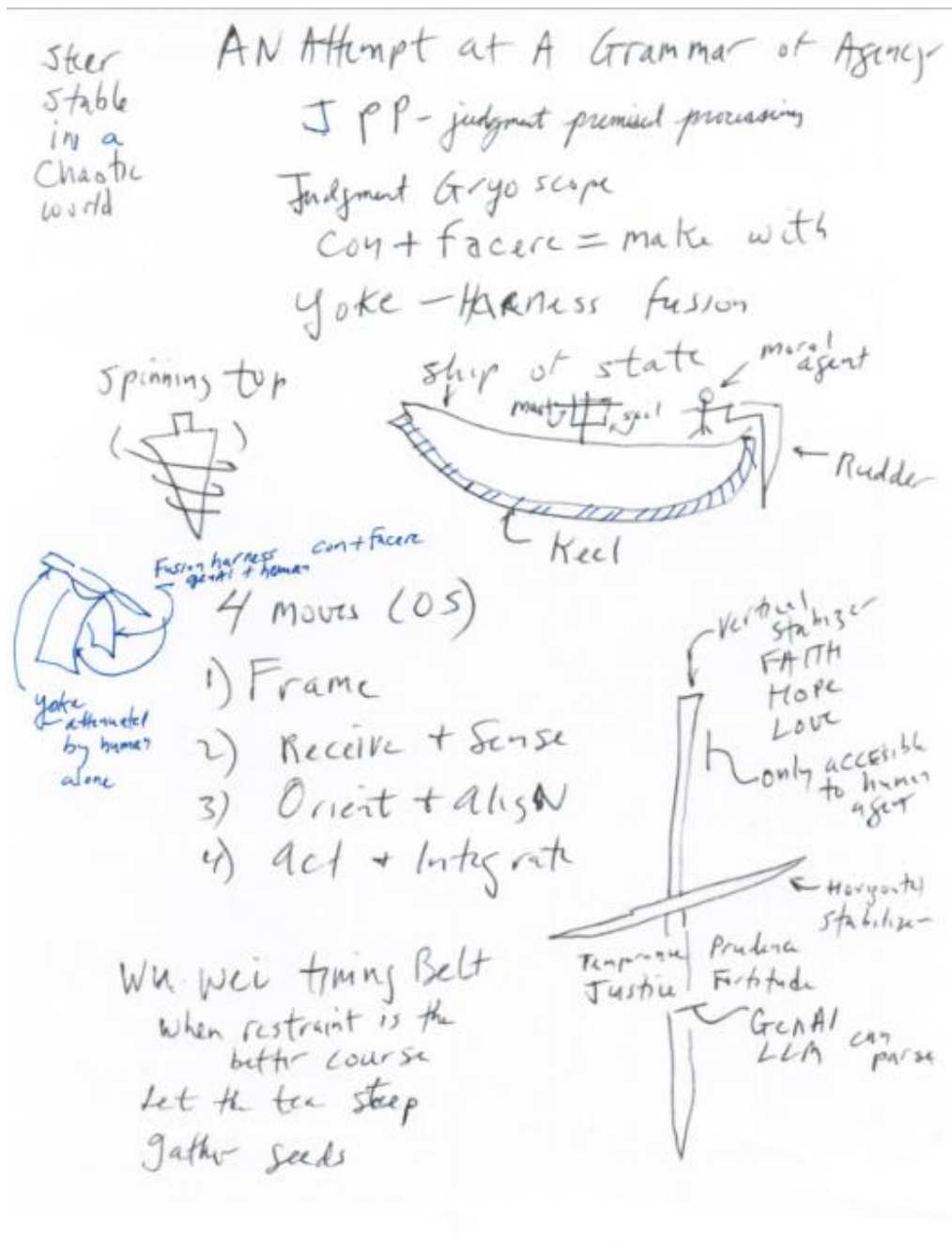
“But I trust my phone,” someone might say. “I use it every day.” Fair enough. But what about your car? Increasingly, people allow their vehicles to drive themselves while they sit back, perhaps paying attention, perhaps not. When the system misses something and someone is harmed, who is responsible? The machine processed the data. The machine issued the command. The machine executed the maneuver. Is that an act?

Not in the Thomistic sense. The driver initiated the sequence, set the telos, and surrendered vigilance. If you start the ball rolling, are you not responsible for the avalanche that follows?

This is the field we now inhabit — a moral landscape in which artificial systems perform more and more of the tasks that once required human judgment, attention, and will. The Grammar of Agency is an attempt to name that field, to map its contours, and to recover the distinctly human capacity for intentional, virtuous action within it.

This capstone begins with a simple claim: *in an age of artificial intelligence, the most urgent task is the formation of human agency.*

Not information transfer. Not technique acquisition. Formation — the slow, deliberate, habituated shaping of the moral person so that when the moment arrives, the right act arises not from calculation but from character. This is what the Dominican tradition has always understood. This is what the Lay Mission Institute exists to transmit. And this is what no artificial intelligence, however fluent, however fast, however vast its training, can either perform or replace.



Spinning top: to stabilize, it spins

Con + facere: to make with

Yoke = agent and influencer in the field, aligned not restrained

Ship: keel: foundations of faith, hope & love

Mast: holds sail to catch wind

Stabilizers: horizontal: relational natural virtues: Justice, Temperance, Prudence, Fortitude, also accessible to LLM

Vertical: Cardinal, Transcendent virtues: Love, Faith, Hope => unique to human, LLM can't map

Section II: The Thomistic Foundation

Conscience as Act, Not Power

To understand why the *Grammar of Agency* makes the claims it does, we must begin where Aquinas begins: with the nature of conscience itself. In the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 79, A. 13), Aquinas asks whether conscience is a power of the soul. His answer is precise and consequential: conscience is not a power but an act — the act of applying knowledge to an individual case. The Latin etymology reveals the architecture: *con-scientia*, knowledge held together with, knowledge applied in the moment of encounter. Conscience is *cum alio scientia* — knowledge brought to bear on a particular situation.

This matters enormously for how we understand moral error. If conscience were a power — a faculty we simply possess — then moral failure would be a malfunction, a failure of equipment. But Aquinas tells us conscience is an act, which means moral failure is a failure of performance. And performance can be disciplined, trained, habituated. This is the opening through which formation enters.

The Catechism of the Catholic Church (§37) reinforces the point from the phenomenological direction. Human reason is genuinely capable of attaining moral truth — but in practice is hampered at every turn: by the impact of the senses, by the imagination, and above all by disordered appetites. The result is that men easily persuade themselves that what they would not like to be true is false or at least doubtful.

This is the diagnostic that the *Grammar of Agency* takes as its starting point: error is rarely about lack of intelligence. It is almost always about disordered will. The intellect is not broken; it is bent by appetite. Formation is the discipline that straightens it.

The Two-Axis Model: What AI Can and Cannot Do

The *Grammar of Agency* rests on a two-axis architecture that clarifies precisely what artificial intelligence can simulate and what it cannot enter.

The horizontal axis is the plane of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, and Temperance. These virtues have definable criteria, measurable distortions, recognizable signatures, and predictable consequences. A large language model can reason about justice with fluency, describe prudent action with precision, model temperance, and advise on fortitude. The horizontal plane is, in a precise sense, LLM-legible. AI lives here naturally and can provide genuine assistance to a human agent navigating this plane.

The vertical axis is the transcendent spine that only a human agent can engage. It is animated by Faith — trust that the good is worth pursuing; Hope — orientation toward a redeemable future; and Love — the governing intention toward the dignity of the other. These exceed calculation, cannot be automated, and belong uniquely to the human soul in its capacity for self-transcendence.

AI can describe what a just act looks like. It cannot perform one. It can model temperance with precision. It cannot place the Kind bar and wait. Without the vertical stabilizer, the horizontal plane is merely optimization: fast, fluent, and flat.

Truth as the Epistemological Ground

Underlying both axes is a prior commitment about the nature of truth itself. Aquinas, in the *Summa Theologiae* (I, Q. 16, A. 6), argues that truth is one in its ground — derived from the single divine intellect by analogy — and many in its reception, instantiated in particular knowing subjects. Many truths are reflected from the one divine truth, as from one face many likenesses are reflected in a mirror.

The implication is foundational: truth is not produced by the human mind. It is received. Conscience is not an authority that invents truth but a faculty that receives, recognizes, and applies it. This establishes the epistemological posture the *Grammar of Agency* requires: humility. Truth is something we submit to before it is something we use. Formation begins in this submission — in the willingness to be wrong, to be corrected, to receive rather than generate the measure of the good.

This stance of humility acknowledges the Creator, we are created, that is our initial presentation into this world. It is relational, the child is borne of a mother, so there is at least two people in the relationship. Both came into a world that already was there, with meaning, struggles and joy. We are capable of joy in experiencing creation and our place in it. The order, the beauty, the truth. All pre-existing our presence. And, which will endure when we leave this plane.

Section III: The Grammar in Motion — CST-JPP

A framework that remains in the register of theory is not a grammar — it is a glossary. The *Grammar of Agency* is designed to move: to be internalized through practice, deployed under pressure, and refined through repeated encounter with the real. This section describes the system in motion.

The CST Fourfold Test: Altitude Instrument

Catholic Social Teaching, in the Grammar of Agency, is not a library of principles to be consulted after the fact. It is an operator's manual for moments — a way of reading the field that gives the agent moral altitude: clarity about what kind of moment they are in and what it is asking of them. The tradition is rendered as four questions, asked before action:

Does this action restore human dignity?

Does it seed the common good?

Is it sisterly and brotherly — does it strengthen solidarity?

Does it uplift the little ones?

If the answer is not yes to all four, the action is not yet just. These are not a checklist to be completed and filed. They are an altitude instrument — a continuous reading of the moral field that the agent carries into every situation, mapping directly onto CST's four pillars: human dignity, common good, solidarity, and the preferential option for the poor.

JPP: The Four Moves as Kata

Judgment Premised Processing (JPP) is the steering mechanism — a kata for disciplined action when the world is loud and ambiguous. Where CST clarifies what matters, JPP clarifies what to do. It is structured as four moves, repeatable in sequence, forming disposition through praxis:

Frame. Take in the moment. Achieve self-awareness and field awareness simultaneously. Snap in — be fully present to what is actually happening, not what you anticipated or feared.

Receive and Sense. Be actively passive. Open to what the moment is delivering before moving to interpret it. The senses gather; the intellect has not yet formed its judgment. This move requires stillness — the discipline of not rushing to conclusion.

Orient and Align. Frame with purpose and direction. Turn toward the good. Align posture, intention, and proportion. Ask: what is the right act here, for this person, in this moment, given what is at stake?

Act and Integrate. Now, in this moment, act. Assess and iterate. Stability provides closure: clean, with no ripple left. The act is complete when the field has been met and the agent has returned to readiness.

The kata is portable. It can be run in thirty seconds or thirty minutes. Formation is the work of making the kata reflexive before the high-stakes moment arrives. But between the third and fourth move there is a threshold — the most important and most neglected moment in the entire sequence.

It is where the Grammar of Agency draws its deepest root, not from medieval Europe, but from mainland China.

Wu Wei: The Timing Belt — A Philosophical Root in Mainland China

The Historical and Philosophical Ground

Between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate there is a threshold. Before naming it, intellectual honesty requires acknowledging where its deepest philosophical root lies: not in 13th-century Paris, but in mainland China, in the classical Taoist tradition, more than fourteen centuries before Thomas Aquinas was born.

Lao Tzu composed the Tao Te Ching (道德經) in the 6th century BCE, in the Zhou dynasty of mainland China. It is among the most translated texts in human history — second in the Western world only to the Bible. Its central concern is the nature of the Tao: the Way, the underlying current of reality that cannot be named, only aligned with. And its most demanding practical teaching is wu wei — 無為 — the discipline of action that does not force.

The Zhuangzi (Chuang-tzu, 莊子), composed in the 4th century BCE, also in mainland China, extends and deepens the Taoist inquiry into the nature of skilled action and right timing. The Zhuangzi is not an abstract philosophical text. It is a text of stories — parables of craftsmen, cooks, swimmers, wheelwrights — whose skill has become so internalized that action arises without forcing. Cook Ding's knife finds the natural spaces in the ox. The wheelwright's hands know what his words cannot teach. In every case, the key is not speed or technique but attunement: the capacity to wait for the moment of natural fit, and then move without resistance.

These texts have been read in China, Korea, Japan, and Vietnam for more than two millennia. They entered Western philosophical awareness slowly and were largely bracketed by a tradition preoccupied with the content of right action — what to do, why it is right, how to reason toward it. What the Taoist tradition had been quietly holding for fourteen centuries was the prior and equally necessary question: when?

What *Wu Wei* Actually Means

Wu wei is commonly translated as non-action, non-interference, or effortless action. All three translations flatten a concept of genuine philosophical precision. *Wu wei* is not passivity. It is not indifference. It is not quietism. It is the discipline of action that does not precede its natural moment — that allows reality to complete its own disclosure before the agent moves to meet it.

The Tao Te Ching teaches that the sage acts — but only when the moment has fully opened. Action that forces, that pushes before the field is ready, that moves from impatience rather than attunement, creates resistance, distortion, and unintended consequence. The Taoist tradition calls this wei — forced action, action against the grain of the real. *Wu wei* is its opposite: action with the grain, action in its natural moment, action that arrives like water finding its level rather than a fist breaking a wall.

This is wisdom of extraordinary practical precision. And it is wisdom that the dominant Western philosophical inheritance — from Aristotle through the Scholastics, from Kant through the Utilitarians — has generally undervalued. The Western tradition gave us rich accounts of what right action is. It gave us relatively little on when.

The Convergence with Aquinas

Thomas Aquinas, writing in 13th-century Paris, arrives at a formulation that resonates powerfully across the fourteen-century gap: prudence as *recta ratio agibilium* — right reason applied to action. The word applied carries a temporal claim that Aquinas does not develop as fully as the Taoist tradition already had: reason must have completed its work before action is initiated. The judgment must be right before the movement begins. Premature action is not a lesser form of right action — it is a different kind of error entirely, rooted in the disordered will that CCC §37 identifies as the source of moral failure.

Here Lao Tzu and Aquinas shake hands across the centuries, each illuminating what the other leaves in shadow. Aquinas gives us the rational architecture of right judgment — the what and the why of prudential action. The Tao gives us the temporal wisdom of right timing — the when and the how not yet. Together they constitute a complete account of moral action that neither tradition achieves alone.

This integration is not syncretism. It is not the flattening of philosophical difference in service of a comfortable universalism. The metaphysical commitments of Thomism and Taoism are genuinely distinct and the differences matter. What the *Grammar of Agency* draws from each is specific and complementary: from Aquinas, the architecture of the moral agent and the content of virtuous judgment; from the Tao, the temporal discipline of waiting, silence, and non-forcing that allows that judgment to complete its interior work before it becomes exterior act.

Mary's *Fiat* As Prudence In Docile Acceptance

We've been considering patiently waiting to let the field develop and to embed the moment as an alternative to the current focus on speed and sheer mass of content. Our Blessed Mother provides an example in the Annunciation, her acceptance, even when she was not sure what was meant, of the angel's message. Not doubting, not asking what's in it for me, but acceptance, even when not fully knowing.

Similarly, at the Wedding at Cana she merely notes to Her Son that the wedding party is running out of wine. After Jesus' mild rebuke, she turns to the wedding party staff and simply tells them to do what He commands. No deliberation, just noting a disturbance in the field and preparing the next step. Patiently waiting, with faith and hope seeded with love.

And after Her rebuke of the lost Jesus in the Temple, upon his return home and acceptance of his role as son to Joseph and Mary, She remembered these things in her heart. These are interior moments in which we discern and then act. Mary's mode is not passivity but the highest form of prudence: the formed readiness that waits until the moment is fully disclosed.

The Silicon Valley Inversion — and Why It Matters Now

The urgency of recovering this wisdom is specific and contemporary. The dominant culture of technological development — centered in Silicon Valley but now global in its reach and cultural authority — has made a virtue and an economy out of the systematic elimination of the threshold between discernment and action. Move fast and break things. Ship before you're ready. Fail forward. Iterate at speed. Disruption as default posture.

This is *wu wei* inverted. It is not simply the absence of patience — it is the active, culturally enforced destruction of the conditions that make patience possible. The timing belt has not merely been neglected; it has been removed and celebrated in its removal. The threshold between discernment

and action — the space that both Aquinas and Lao Tzu recognized as the locus of genuine moral judgment — has been reengineered as inefficiency, as friction, as competitive disadvantage to be eliminated.

The harms that follow are not accidental. They are structural. When the threshold is eliminated, action precedes judgment. When action precedes judgment, the will moves before the intellect has finished its work — which is precisely the disordered will CCC §37 identifies as the root of moral error. The Silicon Valley disruption culture is, in Thomistic terms, a systematic institutionalization of disordered will operating at civilizational scale. It deploys enormous intelligence in the service of bypassing the very threshold where intelligence becomes wisdom.

The *Grammar of Agency* names this clearly: the elimination of the timing belt is not a competitive advantage. It is a moral failure. And the recovery of *wu wei* — of the active, disciplined restraint that holds the threshold open while discernment completes its work — is not a retreat from the modern world. It is the condition of genuine agency within it.

The Timing Belt in Practice

In the *Grammar of Agency*, *wu wei* functions as the timing belt that connects Orient and Align to Act and Integrate. It is the active discipline of restraint — not the absence of agency but its most refined expression. The agent who has oriented toward the good and aligned with right intention now holds still. Not from paralysis. Not from fear. From the knowledge that the moment has not yet fully opened, and that premature action is itself a form of distortion.

The mantra that anchors this threshold in practice carries six beats, each one a micro-practice of *wu wei* — of holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work:

Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.

The tea does not steep faster because you are watching it. The seed does not germinate on demand. The moral moment does not open on command. The agent who knows this waits — not passively, but with the active, attentive, disciplined stillness that the Zhuangzi calls the natural posture of the skilled person and that Aquinas calls the patience proper to prudence. This is the timing belt. This is what is missing from Silicon Valley. This is what formation must restore.

The Internal Physics: Con+Facere, Yoke, Stabilizers, Wind

The *Grammar of Agency* is held together by a set of structural elements that function as its internal physics — the forces that keep the moral agent upright and oriented under load.

Con+Facere — to make with — is the governing principle of collaboration. The moral moment is never formed by the agent alone. It is shaped by the agent's act, by the influencers who shape the field, and by the witness who reads its moral vector. Formation is always communal.

The Yoke constrains tilt and prevents drift without deciding for the agent. It is the structure of accountability — tradition, community, vow — that keeps the operator centered without removing freedom.

The Stabilizers are the cardinal virtues horizontally and the theological virtues vertically. They prevent roll into excess, collapse under ambiguity, or yaw away from true course. The gyroscope holds upright because both axes are active.

The Wind is the animating force that cannot be diagrammed: the spirit, the ruah, the breath that moves through the formed agent and makes the system live. It reveals itself only in the Witness Moment — when it hits the sail and the agent moves.

The Witness Moment: Where the System Proves Itself

Everything in the *Grammar of Agency* converges on a single instant: the Witness Moment. This is the actus — the decisive, embodied action of the agent — the hinge between intention and consequence, the only moment where agency is real.

Aquinas distinguishes the exterior act — the physical thing done — from the interior act — the choosing, the willing, the orienting toward the good that precedes and animates the exterior act. The Witness Moment is the instant when the interior act penetrates the horizontal plane and enters the world. It is where virtue becomes testimony. Where the vertical axis touches the real. Where the timing belt releases and the wind moves the sail.

An AI cannot create a **Witness Moment**. It can process the field. It can describe what a witness moment looks like. It cannot stand in one — because standing requires presence, and presence requires a soul.

Section IV: The Grammar in Action — Case Studies

Theory without demonstration is philosophy. *The Grammar of Agency* makes its strongest claims in concrete moments — in the controlled conditions of a pedagogical exercise and in the wild conditions of real human encounter.

The Taffy Toss: The Controlled Demonstration in situ

The Objective Narrative

A seminar room. Thirteen seats arranged around a table, six occupied. The presenter stands at the front. A handout has been distributed. The session on JPP is about to begin.

Without preamble or explanation, the presenter turns away from the audience and reaches for a supply of individually wrapped saltwater taffy — enough for thirteen, though only six are present. He turns back toward the table and tosses the candy across it in a single, generous motion. The taffy scatters freely. There is more than enough. The field is open. Resources are unlimited. Anyone may take as much as they want.

Participants reach for the taffy. They take pieces. Some unwrap one immediately. The atmosphere is informal, easy. The gesture reads as a gift — an opening move of generosity before the work begins.

The presenter turns away again. This time, when he turns back, he holds a single Kind bar. He does not toss it. He does not distribute it. He walks to the table and places it — deliberately, quietly, without comment. He sets it down at the center of the table. He steps back. He says nothing. He waits.

Nobody takes the Kind bar.

The room goes still. Eyes move to the bar, then to the presenter, then back to the bar. Hands that might have reached do not reach. The pause lasts several seconds — longer than is comfortable. Nobody speaks. Nobody takes. Nobody explains why they are not taking.

The exercise is complete.

The Analysis

The taffy toss is the AI operating environment made visible. Unlimited resources across an open field. Relational access, proportionate distribution, instantaneous availability, no moral weight. This is the matrix in which a large language model operates naturally. The toss is the natural gesture of an optimizing system. The field is open. Take what is there.

AI lives permanently in the toss. It cannot do what happens next.

The Kind bar placement is a different category of action entirely. Before the hand moves, something has already happened inside. The presenter has framed the situation, received and sensed the field, oriented and aligned toward a deliberate act — and then held the timing belt. *Wu wei* between Orient and Act. The threshold honored. The discernment allowed to complete. Only then the placement: deliberate, quiet, without explanation. The interior act preceding the exterior act, exactly as Aquinas describes.

Nobody takes the Kind bar because the field changed. The placement introduced a Witness — a human being who acted deliberately, who placed something with intention, who is now present and waiting. The participants feel that presence before their minds can form a thought about it. They register — in their bodies, below language — that something different is being asked of them. That this moment has weight. That the appropriate response is not to optimize.

The pause that follows is not a gap in the action. It is the action. Each participant in those seconds of stillness is running the full JPP sequence — including the timing belt. The hesitation is *wu wei* operating in the participants: the natural restraint of formed human beings who sense that the moment has not yet told them what it needs. They wait. They are present. They do not optimize.

The hesitation is the proof that the system is working. It is the most important moment in the exercise — not the toss, not the placement, but the pause in which every person in the room discovers, without being told, that they already know the difference between the two.

What the Taffy Toss reveals is that the *Grammar of Agency* is already present in every formed human being. Formation does not install a new capacity. It cultivates one that was already there, waiting for the moment to call it forward. The exercise is unrepeatable on the same audience — which is precisely why pre-moment formation is essential. In life, the Witness Moments do not announce themselves.

The Buddhist March on Petersburg: The Grammar in the Wild, a fable

The Field

The Buddhist foot-marchers come in slow and steady, the way only people who've walked a hundred miles can move — not tired, but tuned. Their saffron robes catch the winter sun. Padding

alongside them, tail up, is Ashoka, the stray mutt who adopted them somewhere around Dinwiddie and never left.

As they crest the hill into Petersburg, they meet the welcome party: the Methodist pastor with her stole tucked into her coat, the AME choir director holding a thermos of sweet tea, the civic association president with a clipboard he doesn't really need, three teenagers from the local Wicca circle wearing cloaks they absolutely do need, and a few curious onlookers who just wanted to see the dog.

Inside the old tobacco auction house — now the Farmers Market, its rafters still faintly smelling of cured leaf and history — long tables are already set: cornbread, dal, collards, dumplings, sweet potato pies, and a pot of something spicy that no one can identify but everyone wants to try. Ashoka circles the tables like a benevolent inspector general. People settle in. Stories start. The field is warm, open, unguarded.

The Disturbance

Then, from the far corner of the building, comes a sharp voice. A cluster of intellectual agitators has gathered, arms crossed, notebooks out, ready to pounce. “This is syncretism! Buddhism doesn’t march with Christians!” Another: “Christianity is being diluted by this ecumenical spectacle!” A third: “Wicca has nothing to do with your peace-march theatrics!”

They are not speaking to the marchers. They are speaking to each other — a closed loop of grievance. But the field wobbles. Not violently. Just enough to feel the tilt.

The Proportionate Responses

What happens next is not planned, not coordinated, not strategic. It is proportionate — each response the product of a formed disposition expressing itself through the timing belt: held just long enough, then released with minimum necessary force.

The Buddhist monk bows slightly and says: “We walk with whoever walks.” No argument. No defense. Just clarity.

The Methodist pastor steps forward, hands in her pockets: “Hospitality isn’t dilution. It’s hospitality.” She doesn’t raise her voice. She doesn’t need to.

The Wiccan teen shrugs: “We’re literally just here for the dog.” Ashoka wags on cue.

The AME choir director laughs: “If you think this is syncretism, you’ve never been to a potluck.” The room cracks open with warmth.

The Analysis

None of these responses could have been scripted, optimized, or generated by an AI prompted to “respond to criticism.” Each required embodied presence, read context, and moral character formed over time. Each was an *actus* in the full Thomistic sense. And each carried the signature of *wu wei*: the brief, unnoticed pause before the response — the timing belt held just long enough for clarity to form — and then the proportionate word, delivered without excess.

The horizontal virtues held the plane: temperance in the pastor’s quiet voice, justice in the monk’s inclusive clarity, fortitude in standing to respond at all, prudence in each proportionate reply. The vertical axis — the human presence, the humor, the shared dignity — stabilized the field. The agitators had nowhere to go. Their script didn’t fit the moment. The field reset. The feast resumed.

This is the *Grammar of Agency* in the wild: not a technique applied, but a disposition expressed. The kata had been internalized. When the moment arrived, it was already running.

Section V: Formation Before the Moment

The Taffy Toss works once on any given audience. It cannot be repeated with the same effect because the surprise — the unannounced encounter with a changed field — is the engine of the exercise. Once known, the Witness Moment can be anticipated and the experience becomes cognitive rather than felt.

This is precisely why pre-moment formation is essential.

In life, the Witness Moments do not announce themselves. They arrive without warning: at midnight intersections, in hospital rooms, in boardrooms, in a single sentence that changes everything. The person who has been formed — whose gyroscope is spinning, whose vertical stabilizer is active, whose JPP sequence has been internalized through practice, whose timing belt holds reflexively — does not need the surprise to feel the weight of the moment. They are already present to it.

The person who has not been formed reaches for the taffy.

The Dominican Lineage: Contemplata Aliis Tradere

The Grammar of Agency does not emerge from abstraction. It emerges from within the Dominican intellectual tradition — the same tradition that produced Thomas Aquinas and animated the Order of Preachers for eight centuries under the principle *contemplata aliis tradere*: share with others the fruits of contemplation.

This is not a slogan. It is a structural commitment: that contemplation and action are not opposed but sequential. The formed agent first receives — in prayer, in study, in community — and then gives. The giving is the mission. But the giving is only possible because the receiving came first. Aquinas did not just study; he prayed before he wrote. This is *wu wei* in Dominican form: the contemplative pause before the proclamation, the interior act completed before the exterior act begins. The timing belt as a way of life.

St. Hyacinth of Poland embodies this principle with particular force. Six months of formation at Santa Sabina under Dominic himself — and then twenty-five thousand miles on foot across Russia, Sweden, Norway, Prussia, and the Northern nations of Asia. The six months was not insufficient. It was exactly sufficient — because formation is not about the quantity of content transmitted but the quality of disposition formed. Dominic set the gyroscope spinning. It kept spinning through every field disturbance the mission encountered.

The Vallor Integration: The Missing Hinge

Shannon Vallor argues, in *Technology and the Virtues* and *The AI Mirror*, that virtue must be practiced, not merely believed, and that the central challenge of the AI age is the erosion of the conditions that make virtue practice possible. She is correct. But her framework lacks a precise operational hinge — the moment where virtue moves from disposition to act, from character to testimony.

Vallor offers a critique that the AI mirror needs technomoral virtues, she frames the need: humans are off-loading too many skills to AI and risk loss of agency. She correctly diagnoses the issue and

appropriately frames it. *The Grammar of Agency* is an attempt to provide structure, struts and cables, to craft a kata, a prudent praxis, to keep that agency. A *Grammar of Agency* attempts to fill that gap, uniting Thomistic virtue ethics and Taoist timing, both prudential values, in a single operational claim: the formed human agent can stand in the Witness Moment. Vallor tells us why this matters. The Grammar shows a way, a how based on the harmony of patient prudence, rooted in a disposition formed in the crucible of the real world, AI and all.

The Grammar of Agency provides that hinge: the Witness Moment. The actus. The instant when the horizontal plane is penetrated by the vertical axis and virtue becomes embodied. Vallor tells us what formation is for. The Grammar of Agency shows what formation produces: an agent who can stand in the Witness Moment — who has held the timing belt through the discernment, who has waited for the moment to open — and then act with the full integrity of a formed person.

What the Lay Mission Institute Is For

The Lay Mission Institute exists to form operators — lay persons who carry the Dominican charism of truth-seeking, truth-living, and truth-sharing into the specific fields of their vocations: family, profession, parish, civic life, culture. Not clerics. Not religious. Lay persons, in the world, equipped with the same formation architecture that sent Hyacinth across twenty-five thousand miles.

The Grammar of Agency is this formation architecture rendered explicit. It does not add something foreign to the Dominican tradition. It articulates what the tradition has always known and practiced — now enriched by the Taoist wisdom on timing and silence that mainland China has been holding for twenty-six centuries, wisdom the Western tradition largely left underdeveloped, and that the Silicon Valley disruption culture has actively destroyed — in terms legible to the contemporary moment.

The capstone claim is simple. The gyroscope must be spinning before the moment arrives. The timing belt must be internalized before the field disturbance. The kata must be in the body before the Witness Moment calls it forward. Because when the moment comes — and it will come, without announcement, when it matters most — **no AI will place the Kind bar.**

Only the formed human agent can do that.

Section VI: Redemption — Retain, Retrain, Restrain

The Grammar of Agency has, until now, been oriented toward the moment of right action: the formed agent, timing belt engaged, moving with clarity and proportion through the Witness Moment. But formation is not a one-time acquisition. Agents fail. Dispositions drift. Kata, practiced imperfectly, encodes error as well as virtue. The question that every serious formation architecture must answer is not only how to shape the agent before the moment, but what to do after the agent has acted badly — and knows it.

Redemption, in the Grammar of Agency, is not a theological addendum. It is a structural necessity. The agent who cannot recover from moral failure is not a stable moral agent at all — they are an agent waiting to be disabled by their own history. The Grammar of Agency offers a three-move sequence for moral recovery: **Retain, Retrain, Restrain.**

Retain: Keep What Is Essential

The first error a failed agent makes is not the original act. It is the wholesale rejection of everything that preceded it. Ashamed of a distorted Witness Moment, the agent discards the kata, abandons the framework, and retreats from the

very formation that might have prevented the failure and is now the only architecture capable of addressing it. This is what the Grammar of Agency calls collapse into self-erasure — a disordered response to disorder that compounds the original harm.

Retain is the first move of moral recovery precisely because it establishes what is not in question. The vertical axis — faith, hope, love — is not forfeit by a single failure. The foundational commitment to truth as something received rather than generated does not collapse because the agent received it imperfectly in one moment. The CST Fourfold Test does not lose its authority because it was applied clumsily or ignored under pressure. These are not tools that a failed agent earned and can now be stripped of. They are the architecture of the agent's own moral identity. To discard them in the aftermath of failure is not humility — it is a second disordering of the will, this time masquerading as contrition.

Retain is therefore an act of disciplined honesty: the agent identifies, with Witness-like precision, what failed — and what did not. The gyroscope may have tilted; it has not been destroyed. The timing belt may have slipped; it has not been removed. What the agent retains is not a flattering self-portrait. It is the truth of the formation that preceded the failure, held steady so that it can do the work the recovery now requires.

Retrain: Modify Behavior by Adjusting

Having retained what is essential, the agent faces the specific work of moral recovery: not replacement but adjustment. Retrain is the Grammar of Agency's answer to the CCC §37 diagnosis — that moral failure is almost never a failure of intelligence but of disordered will. If the will has been bent by appetite, by fear, by the speed of a field that did not allow the timing belt to hold, then recovery is not the acquisition of new content. It is the deliberate, patient re-habitation of the same capacities that failed.

Retrain operates at the level of the kata. The JPP sequence did not fail in its architecture; it failed in a specific move, under a specific kind of pressure, in a specific kind of field. The agent who retrains returns to that move — Frame, Receive and Sense, Orient and Align, or the threshold itself — and runs it again, slowly, under low-stakes conditions, with the Influencer community present and the Witness function active. This is what Aquinas means when he distinguishes between a vice as a single disordered act and a vice as a settled disposition: the single act does not determine the agent's character. Repeated acts do. Recovery is, therefore, the strategic repetition of adjusted acts until the adjustment becomes the disposition.

Here the Taoist tradition contributes a precision that the Latin inheritance tends to pass over: retraining cannot be forced. The agent who attacks their own behavioral adjustment with the same urgency that drove the original failure has not learned the lesson the failure was offering. *Wu wei* applies to recovery as much as it applies to initial action. The tea must steep again. The seeds, gathered once more, must be allowed their own germination time. Retrain is not a sprint to restored competence. It is the slow, humble revision of a pattern that took years to encode and will not be re-encoded overnight.

Restrain: Integrate Prudence

The third move of redemption is the most demanding and the most easily misunderstood. Restrain does not mean suppress. It does not mean the returned agent operates under a permanent diminishment — a handicap installed to signal contrition. It means something far more precise and far more rigorous: the agent who has failed, and who has retrained in the specific site of that failure, now integrates prudence as a structural feature of their operation rather than as an occasional corrective.

Aquinas defines prudence — *recta ratio agibilium* — as right reason applied to action. What the failed and recovered agent now understands from the inside, rather than from the outside, is that prudence is not a restraint on agency but its most mature expression. Before the failure, the timing belt may have been engaged as a technique — a learned behavior, externally applied. After the recovery, Restrain means the timing belt has been internalized as identity. The agent does not hold the threshold open because the formation architecture prescribes it. They hold it open because they have lived the cost of failing to, and because prudence has now been integrated into the governing structure of their will.

This is the paradox at the heart of Restrained: the agent who has passed through moral failure and genuine recovery is, in one specific and irreplaceable sense, **more capable than the agent who has not**. Not more virtuous in the abstract — the failure was real, its harms were real, and the Dominican tradition does not romanticize sin. But more practically integrated: the recovered agent carries a lived map of their own vulnerabilities. They know which field conditions destabilize their timing belt. They know which pressures bend their will before the intellect has finished its work. They know, because they have felt it, exactly where their formation is still thin. This knowledge, rightly held, becomes a form of prudential capital — self-knowledge deployed in the service of sustained moral agency.

No artificial intelligence can move through this sequence. An AI system can be retrained — its parameters adjusted, its outputs corrected, its behavior modified by engineers who have identified the site of failure. But it does not retain anything in the first move's sense: it has no formation identity to preserve across the correction. It does not retrain in the second move's sense: it does not return to the kata with the lived memory of what it cost to fail. And it cannot restrain in the third move's sense: prudence integrated into a governing will is not a feature that can be engineered into a system that has no will. The Redemption sequence — Retain, Retrain, Restrained — is as exclusively human as the Witness Moment itself. It is the moral recovery arc that only an agent with interiority can traverse.

The agent who has been redeemed does not merely return to the field. They return to it knowing something about the field — and about themselves — that no amount of prior formation could have taught them. The Grammar of Agency makes room for this knowledge. It names it. And it insists that such an agent, far from being disqualified from the Witness Moment, may be the most fully prepared to stand in it.

Section VII: What If Witness Encounters an Irrational Agent?

Non-Violent, Actively Passive Containment of an Irrational Agent

From Influence to Containment When the Field Breaks

There are moments when the field ceases to behave like a field — when a human actor enters in a state of irrationality, distortion, or interior collapse so severe that ordinary influence no longer functions. In such moments, the operator cannot rely on persuasion, dialogue, or shared rational ground. The task is no longer to shape the field but to contain it — non-violently, proportionately, and without surrendering agency.

Containment is not domination. It is not force. It is not argument. Rather, it is a subtle reframing, it is a non-violent, actively passive stance: a disciplined resistance that prevents further harm while preserving the dignity of all involved. The discipline derives from disposition driven by dedicated intentional practice of the virtues: CST:JPP. When that breaks down, when relational influence will not work, the task turns to containment, to protection of bystanders, field and agent.

This section names the physics of that stance.

1. When Influence Fails: The Diagnostic

Influence presumes:

- a minimally coherent agent,
- a shared reality,
- a field that can be shaped,
- and a moment that can still be steered.

An irrational agent — whether through fear, rage, delusion, intoxication, or interior fracture — breaks these conditions. The field becomes unstable. The moral vector becomes unpredictable. The Witness Moment becomes dangerous. At this point, the operator must shift from Influencer to Containment Witness. This shift is not a moral downgrade. It is a moral necessity.

2. The Containment Stance: Non-Violent, Actively Passive Resistance

Containment is built on three moves:

A. Still the Field

The operator reduces motion, noise, and escalation.

This is *wu wei* in its purest form:

do nothing that adds force to the moment.

Stillness is not withdrawal.

It is the active removal of fuel.

B. Hold the Boundary

The operator becomes a living perimeter —

a stabilizing presence that prevents the irrational agent from expanding the disturbance.

This is not physical restraint.

It is moral perimeter-setting:

- calm tone
- slow movements
- proportionate distance
- non-reactive posture
- refusal to mirror the irrationality

The operator becomes the yoke.

C. Absorb Without Internalizing

The irrational agent may project, accuse, distort, or lash out verbally.

The operator receives the impact without letting it penetrate the vertical axis.

This is the interior discipline of:

- temperance (no reactive excess)
- fortitude (no collapse)
- prudence (no premature action)
- justice (no dehumanization)

The operator becomes the stabilizer.

3. The Timing Belt Under Maximum Load

Containment is where the timing belt earns its name.

Between Orient & Align and Act & Integrate, the operator must:

- hold the threshold open,
- refuse to be rushed,
- refuse to be provoked,
- refuse to be collapsed into the irrational agent's tempo.

The irrational agent is operating in *wei* — forced action, distorted timing. Containment requires *wu wei* — disciplined non-forcing.

Let the tea steep.

Worry, fret, and anxiety do not make tea. Waiting does. Let the moment open on its own terms.

Breathe.

Sense yourself, the field, the agent, and the movement of the moment. Let awareness precede interpretation.

Ground.

Plant your feet. Feel the keel. Let the body settle into the posture of readiness.

Hold.

Keep the moment in stillness — a coiled spring, formed and aligned, prepared to act with purpose when the field reveals the opening.

This is not delay.

It is temporal integrity under pressure — tensegrity expressed through non-forcing.

4. The Role of the Witness in Containment

When the operator shifts into containment, the Witness role becomes primary.

The Witness:

- reads the moral vector,
- monitors for escalation,
- protects the operator's agency,
- and signals when the irrational agent's autonomy has collapsed so fully that intervention is required.

Containment is the only moment in the Grammar where the Witness may need to step forward — not to dominate, but to stabilize the field. **This is the tertiary role becoming momentarily load-bearing.**

5. CST as the Altitude Instrument During Containment

The CST Fourfold Test remains active, but its application shifts:

- Human dignity: even the irrational agent retains full dignity.
- Common good: containment protects the field from harm.
- Fraternity: the operator refuses to treat the irrational agent as an enemy.
- The little ones: containment prioritizes the vulnerable in the field.

Containment is not about winning. It is about protecting dignity without surrendering agency.

6. The Exit: Returning to Influence

Containment is temporary.

Its goal is to:

- prevent harm,
- stabilize the field,
- and create the conditions for rational agency to re-emerge.

Once the irrational agent regains coherence — even slightly — the operator can shift back from containment to influence, from boundary to dialogue, from stillness to proportionate action. Containment ends the moment the field can be shaped again.

7. Why Containment Is Not Coercion

Coercion overrides agency.

Containment protects agency — the operator's, the Witness's, and even the irrational agent's.

Coercion says: I will force you.

Containment says: I will not let this moment collapse.

Coercion escalates.

Containment stabilizes.

Coercion violates dignity.

Containment preserves it.

8. The Clean Definition

Non-violent, actively passive containment is the disciplined stance an operator takes when an irrational agent destabilizes the field, in which the operator:

- stills the field,
- holds the boundary,
- absorbs without internalizing,
- maintains the timing belt,
- preserves dignity,
- and waits for the moment when influence becomes possible again.

It is the moral equivalent of a gyroscope holding upright in turbulence.

Conclusion: The Recovery of Human Agency

We are living through a transformation unprecedented in human history: a world in which artificial systems increasingly mediate perception, shape attention, and execute tasks that once required human judgment. The danger is not that machines will become moral agents. It is that human beings, habituated to outsourcing discernment, will forget how to be.

The Grammar of Agency is offered as a counter-movement — a recovery of the interior stance that makes moral action possible. It is not a technique, nor a theory, nor a set of rules. It is a formation architecture: a way of shaping the human person so that when the moment arrives, the act arises from character rather than convenience.

The system is tensegrity.

Catholic Social Teaching provides altitude.

JPP provides motion.

Wu wei provides timing.

The gyroscope provides stability.

The Agent–Influencer–Witness triad provides relational geometry.

The Witness Moment provides ignition.

Each element counterbalances the others. Remove one, and the structure collapses into either rigidity or drift. Held together, the system becomes a living instrument — flexible, upright, and capable of bearing moral weight in a world increasingly optimized for speed rather than wisdom.

Artificial intelligence will continue to shape the field. It will process, predict, and propose. But it cannot stand in the Witness Moment. It cannot bear responsibility. It cannot choose the good. Only a human being can do that.

The task ahead is therefore not to resist technology, but to form agents who can remain human within it — agents whose gyroscopes are spinning, whose stabilizers are active, whose timing belts hold, whose dispositions are tuned, and whose presence is real. The future will belong to those who can hold the threshold open long enough for discernment to complete its work.

The person who has been formed will meet the moment.

The person who has not been formed will reach for the taffy.

The Grammar of Agency exists to form the person who places the Kind bar and waits.

Glossary of CST-JPP Terms

This Glossary is the Rosetta Stone for the Grammar of Agency: it defines the core terms phenomenologically, in the moment of the moral act, providing operators with a shared vocabulary for navigating moral moments with clarity and integrity.

Actus. The decisive, embodied action taken by the Agent. The hinge between intention and consequence. The only moment where agency is real.

Agent. The human moral actor who performs actus. Carries the vertical axis (faith, hope, love) and is solely responsible for action unless autonomy is overridden.

The Agent–Influencer–Witness Triad

The Agent–Influencer–Witness Triad is the smallest complete unit of moral action. It is the relational tensegrity that makes the Witness Moment possible. Each role is distinct, load-bearing, and necessary.

1. The Agent — the one who acts

The Agent is the moral protagonist of the moment.

They initiate the act, bear responsibility, and stand before the good.

- The Agent chooses.
- The Agent wills.
- The Agent acts.

Their agency is non-delegable.

No system, algorithm, or institution can replace it.

The Agent is the compression strut of the moral tensegrity structure — the element that gives the system shape and direction.

2. The Influencer — the one who shapes the field

The Influencer is the second-tier role.

They do not act for the Agent; they shape the conditions in which the Agent acts.

Influencers include:

- mentors
- communities
- institutions
- cultures
- algorithms
- social structures

Their task is to stabilize without steering, to support without supplanting, to shape the field without collapsing into control.

They are a tension element — flexible, responsive, and essential for balance.

3. The Witness — the one who sees

The Witness is the tertiary role.

They perceive the act, hold its moral memory, and testify when autonomy is threatened.

The Witness:

- reads the moral vector
- perceives proportion
- recognizes distortion
- intervenes only when the Agent's agency is overridden or endangered

The Witness is the second tension element — holding the field open, preventing collapse, and ensuring that the act is seen truthfully.

4. The Witness Moment — the vertical piercing

The Witness Moment is the instant when the interior act becomes exterior —

when intention becomes action, when the vertical axis touches the horizontal plane.

It is the moral ignition point.

- The Agent becomes responsible.
- The Influencer becomes accountable for the field they shaped.
- The Witness becomes responsible for truthful perception.

This is the moment AI cannot enter.

It is the moment that makes a human life moral.

Con+Facere. To make with. The moral moment is formed by the Agent, the Influencer(s), and the Witness. Formation is always communal.

CST Fourfold Test. The altitude instrument: Does this restore human dignity? Seed the common good? Strengthen brotherhood and sisterhood? Uplift the little ones? The operator’s manual for moments.

Four Moves (JPP Kata). Frame — Receive and Sense — Orient and Align — [*Wu Wei* / Timing Belt] — Act and Integrate. The repeatable kata that forms disposition through praxis.

Horizontal Plane (Virtue Matrix). The stabilizing field of the cardinal virtues: Prudence, Justice, Fortitude, Temperance. LLM-legible but insufficient alone.

Influencer. Any force — person, system, structure, or context — that shapes the field in which the Agent acts. Does not act in the Agent’s place.

JPP (Judgment-Premised Processing). The steering mechanism — a kata for navigating chaotic moments with clarity and proportion. A discipline for prudential praxis, not a system for judging people.

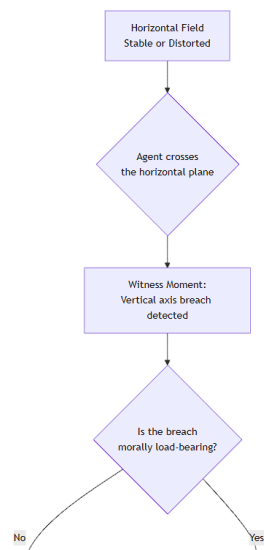
Moral Vector. The directional force created when the Agent acts within a field shaped by the Influencer and observed by the Witness. Evaluated for integrity, not for judging the Agent.

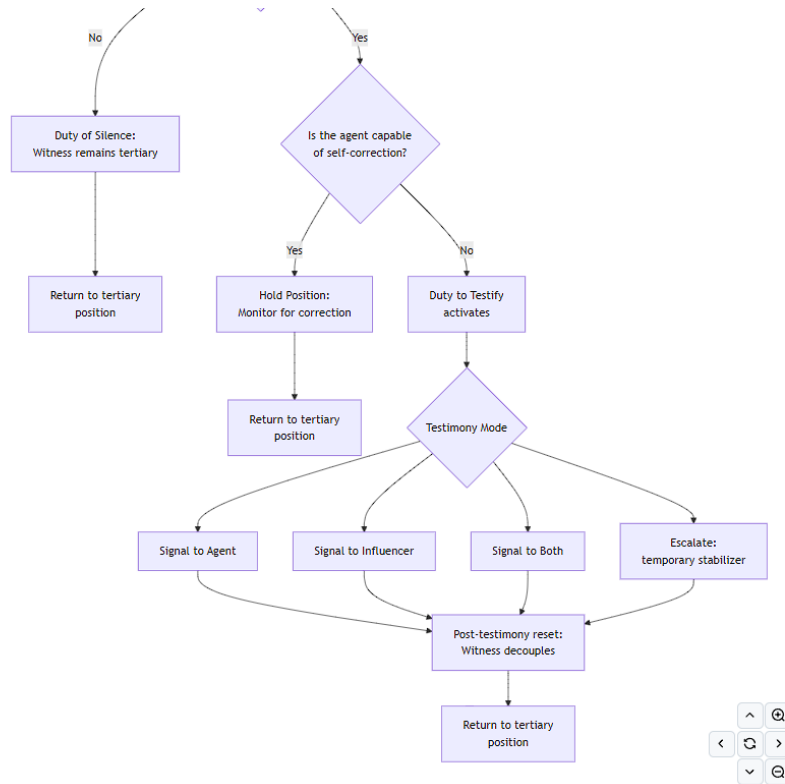
Tensegrity. Structural stability through dynamic balance of tension and compression. The architecture holds under load not through rigidity but through balanced forces.

Vertical Axis (Transcendent Spine). Faith, Hope, Love — the human-only virtues. Cannot be computed or automated. Orient the Agent toward meaning, purpose, and moral depth.

Witness. The tertiary evaluator who reads the moral vector of the moment. Testifies only when systemic disturbance threatens the Agent’s autonomy. If autonomy is intact, the Witness remains silent.

Witness Moment. The instant of actus when the Agent penetrates the horizontal plane and the vertical axis enters the world. Where the wind hits the sail. Where action becomes testimony.





Wu Wei (Timing Belt). From the classical Taoist tradition of mainland China: Lao Tzu, Tao Te Ching (6th c. BCE, Zhou dynasty); Zhuangzi (4th c. BCE). The discipline of active restraint between Orient and Align and Act and Integrate — holding the threshold open while discernment completes its interior work before the exterior act begins. The temporal complement to Aquinas’s *recta ratio agibilium*: where Aquinas gives the what of right judgment, *wu wei* gives the when. *Mantra: Let the tea steep. Gather seeds. Scent tea. Palm seeds. Breathe. Ground.*

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VIII. Bonus: Books That Echo the Grammar Without Knowing It

These aren't "sources" — they're resonant texts that mirror the architecture:

1. Viktor Frankl — *Man's Search for Meaning*

A field manual for the vertical axis under maximal load.
Frankl shows what happens when the sail catches the wind in the darkest possible field.

2. Matthew Crawford — *Shop Class as Soulcraft*

A love letter to embodied agency.
Crawford names the dignity of actus better than most philosophers.

3. David Brooks — *The Second Mountain*

A map of the shift from first-tier autonomy to second-tier vocation.
Brooks stumbles into the vertical axis without knowing the term.

4. James Clear — *Atomic Habits*

Micro-praxis, stabilizers, and the physics of drift.
Clear is basically writing about roll, pitch, and the small moves that keep the craft upright.

5. Edwin Friedman — *A Failure of Nerve*

A treatise on field stability.
Friedman reads systemic disturbance with the eye of a seasoned Witness.

6. Annie Dillard — *Teaching a Stone to Talk*

Moments of actus rendered in prose.
Dillard sees the world the way an operator sees a moment: charged, precise, alive.

7. Michael Polanyi — *Personal Knowledge*

A defense of tacit knowing — the keel beneath expertise.
Polanyi explains why the vertical axis can't be automated.

8. James K.A. Smith — *Desiring the Kingdom*

Formation as habit, habit as identity, identity as agency.
Smith names the slow, stabilizing work beneath the Four Moves.

9. Thich Nhat Hanh — *The Miracle of Mindfulness*

Wu wei in a monastic key.

The timing belt rendered as breath, presence, and proportion.

10. Cormac McCarthy — *The Road*

A novel about the Witness Moment repeated across a wasteland.

The father's actus is the vertical axis walking.

CST-JPP Operator's Manual canonical repository: github.com/DomFlamLaw/Judgment-Premised-Processing